

A man with a mustache, wearing a light-colored striped shirt and dark trousers, is climbing a coconut tree. He is using a black metal device that is attached to the tree trunk. He has one foot on a platform and his other leg is raised. He is looking towards the camera and has his right arm raised in a thumbs-up gesture. The background is a lush green tropical forest with many palm trees.

fruit of LABOUR

✱ **M.J. Joseph Appachan, 50**

Project A coconut tree-climbing device

Can-do Icon His father Joseph, a small-scale farmer who nurtured in him an interest in technology

There are **16 crore** palm trees in Kerala

shop too. In 2006, Appachan received a patent for the gear which is being produced and marketed by organisations like the Central Coconut Board (CCB) and the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research-backed National Innovation Foundation (NIF). "This is one of the products for which we have the largest number of inquiries, not just from India but from researchers abroad too. The latest is from a botanist in the US," says Arul George Skaria of NIF. As NIF's Gupta says, "We used to tell the Americans that you may be able to go to the moon, but you will still need Appachan's climbing device to go up a tree."

Appachan got his first financial assistance of Rs 4,000 in the form of a loan from a grameen bank in north Malappuram. Later, he received Rs 16,000 from the state-owned Kerala Financial Corporation to set up his workshop. NIF gave him a grant of Rs 1 lakh and the CCB bore the expenses of marketing the device in the country. Currently, he has orders for about 100 such devices from the CCB. NIF has exported the gear to seven countries on an experimental basis. Appachan has sold about 4,000 coconut tree climbing devices. The price for a device made of iron weighs 6-8 kg is Rs 1,500 while that made of stainless steel costs Rs 4,500. The production costs of an iron and a stainless steel device are Rs 1,000 and Rs 2,500 respectively. Though Appachan could not get much formal education in his childhood, he had the gift of learning about his surroundings. And it is this learning that he has effectively put into use to climb the steep wall of success.